Ironically, the Government of India, on receipt of the first telegraphic reports of the protests, too conceded that it originated in the shipping rivalry. If the secretary of state for India, Lord Morley wondered from London if the protests were against ‘specific industrial grievances or was political’, the home secretary to the Government of India, Herbert H. Risley, too wanted to know ‘the part played in the disturbances by the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company which has for some time past been trying to cut out the British Indian Steam Navigation Company in the traffic between Tuticorin and Colombo’.[70] It was later that it toed the line of the Madras government and understood the political significance of VOC’s shipping venture.



That the government was only waiting for an opportunity to crush SSNCo needs no belabouring. Seeing VOC as the villain of the piece, it took to the judicial route to silence him. On 25 March, the High Court of Madras quashed the security proceedings on the grounds that the magistrate could not refuse to accept security when offered. VOC was released only to be immediately rearrested—‘the moment they came out of the Palamcottah gaol’, in the words of the convicting judge—but now on charges of sedition and abetment of (Subramania Siva’s) seditious speeches under sections 124A and 153A of the Indian Penal Code. The energies of VOC, an undertrial in Palayamkottai Central Jail from 12 March until 7 July, were focused on his defence—he was now completely removed from the scene of his beloved shipping company.

The trial in the court of the District Sessions Judge of Tinnevelly proceeded daily. With the proceedings being reported in the press all over India, news about SSNCo travelled wide. As one of the earliest sedition cases in the presidency—‘true, the case is the first of its kind in the Presidency’ observed the judge himself—its outcome was eagerly awaited. Scores of witnesses were called and dozens of exhibits submitted. While at least five of SSNCo’s directors testified in VOC’s defence, Eric Chapman,